**Tradition (re)visited: from place to presence**

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Abstract
Three ways of encountering objects belonging to our cultural heritage can be distinguished. We may encounter an object in its traditional environment, we may encounter an object in an environment of preservation, and we may encounter an object in an environment of representation. These three ways of encountering objects provide a framework for addressing the question how we relate ourselves to cultural heritage by means of digital media. Digital reproductions of our cultural heritage belong to the third way of encountering objects. In our present day we first and foremost relate ourselves to tradition by representing it, whereas before we first and foremost related ourselves to tradition by remembering it. Places of memory are exchanged for the presence of representation in a culture driven by information technology.

Digital imaging, simulations, reconstructions, search-engines, and visualization, are but a few examples of representing tradition with the help of information technology.[1] These technologies not only change the practices of cultural heritage institutions entrusted with the task of preserving tradition, they also change the way we relate ourselves to tradition.

In this paper, three ways of encountering objects belonging to our cultural heritage will be distinguished, using such concepts as authenticity, consciousness, memory, and history. This way we will acquire a conceptual framework that enables us to address the question how we relate ourselves to cultural heritage by means of digital media. This framework will also help us to surpass the binary oppositions in terms of which this question is usually dealt with, opposition such as the real versus the virtual, the material versus the immaterial, and the original versus the copy.[2]

This paper's thesis is that in our present day we first and foremost relate ourselves to tradition by representing it, whereas before we first and foremost related ourselves to tradition

[1] Examples and analysis of these impressive technologies can be found in Mark Greengrass and Lorna Hughes eds. (2008) and Manos Baltsavias, Armin Gruen, Luc van Goold, and Maria Pateraki eds. (2006).
[2] For a critical analyses of these oppositions and their shortcomings, see Fiona Cameron (2007).

by remembering it. Places of memory are exchanged for the presence of representation in a culture driven by information technology.

**1. Tradition visited**

There are three ways of encountering objects belonging to our cultural heritage. An object can be part of tradition, it can remind us of once being part of tradition, and the object being part of tradition can be represented or itself be representative ofthat tradition. I take objects to be tangible heritage as well as the intangible heritage associated with it.

Coming across an object in its original environment means encountering that object in the environment of its original use value. Think for example of a farmer plowing his field, a catholic visiting his church, a cave painting bestowing a successful hunt, or an imperial statue causing a feeling of awe and submissiveness. In these examples, the plow, the church, the painting, and the statue, are part of the domain of tradition.

A second way we may encounter an object is in an environment preserving that object, while visiting an archeological excavation or a museum for example. The farmer's tools may be exhibited in a museum. The church may at some moment cease to function as a place of worship and instead be turned into a monument to be visited during opening hours. The cave painting may lose its ability to provide a successful hunt and turn out to be pre-historic art. The imperial statue, apart from being removed to protect it from weather and greenhouse gasses, may no longer cause a feeling of awe and submissiveness by its visitor, and instead be admired for its aesthetic qualities, even if the statue reminds its visitor of its original use value. Objects in an environment of preservation are reminiscent of the tradition the objects once belonged to.

A third way we may encounter an object is in its documented or representational environment. Reading information concerning the provenance of an object or a story about farmers and Catholics are such means of encountering objects. Not only words are able to document an object. A photograph, if not an artwork in its own right, is a means of documenting an object too. Similarly, a reconstruction of a peasant village documents that village. Visiting a reconstruction of a pre-historic cave or a Roman forum is visiting a place documenting that cave or forum.

The domain of representation also encompasses objects which are representative of their own past. These objects are documents themselves. If the plow is exhibited in a series of farmer's tools representing agricultural tradition, the plow may lose its autonomy and become a document in itself, representative of the tradition it once belonged to. If a museum exhibits an object in a reconstruction or mimetic recreation of a traditional environments, then the object is

displayed in situ. If an object is exhibited in such a way that the object is representative of the tradition it once belonged to, then the object is displayed in context.[3] In both cases the objects represent tradition rather than remind their visitors of a tradition being over.

For a proper understanding of these three ways of encountering objects belonging to our cultural heritage, we must realize that the same object at one moment is part of the first domain, at another part of the second domain, and at some moment will only be encountered by means of its representation or as representative of its tradition.

We should also keep in mind that museum practices have a history too: they are part of a tradition of collecting and exhibiting. This not only explains why there are such things as museums of museums, that is, museums documenting museum practices, but also why an object is preserved or turned into a document itself.

Not all objects once belonged to tradition. This is true of such things as natural stones and seashells, except of course of those stones and shells that were collected for their magical, aesthetic, or representative qualities. Stones in a museum of natural history for example, are collected for being representative of some part of the past and thus were once part of a tradition of collecting natural history objects.

**2. Tradition, authenticity and the virtual**

The concept of authenticity may help us better understand these three ways of encountering objects. The authenticity of a thing is according to Walter Benjamin "the essence of all that is transmissible from its beginning, ranging from its substantive duration to its testimony to the history which it has experienced."[4] Authenticity is thus something that an object acquires. To be authentic, an object needs to accumulate a history.

Following this definition of authenticity we may contend that in an environment of preservation objects are preserved for having collected a history.[5] The concept of authenticity in an environment of preservation thus refers to the object's former environment: the domain of tradition in which the object collected its history. We may say something similar regarding the concept of authority: the authority of an object in an environment of preservation depends on its original use value. For the reference to its original use value provides the object with an aura of authority.

[3] On the distinction between displaying in situ and displaying in context see Kirshenblatt-Gimblett (1998, pp.19-23).
[4] Benjamin (1999, p. 215).
[5] An object taken out of its original environment does not cease to collect a history in the sense that in a preserved environment, the history of the object becomes part of the history of collecting and exhibiting practices of the institution preserving the object.

The authenticity of an object in the sense of its accumulated history is not the only sense of authenticity we have. For one can also argue that the authenticity of objects depends on its documentation. In that case, the authenticity of an object in a preserved environment refers to its documentation. Again, the same is true of the concept of authority. It is because experts make and control the records of objects that their documentation is authoritative. Documenting is not just a matter of administration, registration, and the preservation of information. Documenting objects is foremost providing historical testimonies, and with it a sense of authenticity and authority.

There are thus two senses of authenticity. Authenticity in the sense of the object's accumulated history and authenticity in the sense of its documentation. Only unique objects may accumulate such history for only unique objects have a singular existence in time. Reproductions on the other hand, are at best part of the history of the unique item. They do not collect a history by themselves for they have no singular existence in time, as Benjamin emphasized.[6] So reproductions can only be related to the second sense of authenticity. They document the objects they are a reproduction of.

Once could oppose distinguishing between these two senses of authenticity by arguing that there is but one sense since the second sense is simply a record of the first. Moreover, the documentation of the object gives us the accumulated history rather than the other way around. The authenticity of an object is a social construct, depending on dominant curatorial and discursive practices, leaving no room for authenticity in its first sense.[7] This argument need not convince us. For in case of the second sense of authenticity, the material presence of the object is indifferent, while the reverse does not hold. Since there is a difference between the presence and absence of material objects, there is a difference between authenticity as the accumulated history of the object and authenticity as the documentation or testimony of the object. Obviously this difference is important when discussing the differences between particular objects and digital reproductions.

Museums and archeological sites guard the authenticity of artifacts by preserving them. The question is whether this is still true if we encounter those artifacts in a virtual environment. This question is justified by two considerations.

First one could argue that in a virtual environment we do not encounter objects belonging to our heritage but instead encounter reproductions of them. Since these reproductions lack a singular existence in time, they have not accumulated a history and therefore lack authenticity. It follows that virtual museums cannot function as guardians of the

[6] Benjamin (1999, p. 214)

[7] On authenticity as a social construct, see Cameron (2007, pp. 54-57). In Cameron's analysis there is no room for our first sense of authenticity. Cf. below n23.

authenticity of objects. Next one could argue that in a virtual environment the distinction between reproduction and heritage disappears. Since a digital file is identical to its copy, there is no difference to be made between copies and originals in a virtual environment. The reproduction of our heritage, then, implies losing the connection with heritage itself. This is even more so if we realize that in a virtual environment objects are everywhere at any time as long as they are processed.

Both arguments are much rehearsed in studies on the impact of new media, making use of respectively the original-copy and the material-immaterial opposition. But there is more to it. If heritage is encountered apart from any sense of place and time, we may doubt whether there is still anything left of our sense of cultural heritage. Along these lines Jeff Malpas has warned us that "that which is culturally significant is not mere 'information' but is itself tied to particular places and things". This "sense of place" is "bound up intimately with a sense of heritage, as well as with a sense of culture. Thus, inasmuch as new media threatens our sense of place, so it also threatens our sense of cultural heritage".[8] The same might be argued for in terms of time. If new media threatens our sense of time, it also threatens our sense of cultural heritage. So the digital reproduction of our cultural heritage threatens our sense of authenticity (and its closely related notion of authority), for the authenticity of an object *is* its collected history, and that history is in danger of getting lost in a virtual environment.

But as we have argued, authenticity in the sense of the object's accumulated history is not the only sense of authenticity we have. The authenticity of an object can also be identified with its documentation. So even if the first sense of authenticity is lost in a virtual environment, the second sense might still be there, taking the place of the first. If so, the virtual museum might be called a *documentation-museum*.

One could further argue that in a virtual environment there is a *need* for documentation. Since digital files are so easily multiplied and distributed, they need to be anchored to the object they document. If not, representations will eventually only be identified as belonging to a certain type instead of also being about a particular object. Rigaud's painting of Louis XIV may then first turn into a Louis XIV painting and subsequently into a king painting or even a man-with-wig painting. Furthermore, by anchoring the digital file to the object, the file is linked to the place where the original object is kept. That way the documentation can still be verified.

Digital reproductions of our cultural heritage belong to the third way of encountering objects only. They document tradition by representing it. Before I further argue this, I will first elaborate on the three ways of encountering objects.

[8] Malpas (2008, p.198).

**3. Tradition, memory and history**

The environment of an object's original use value is the domain of tradition. This is the domain of habits, gestures, and passed down skills from generation to generation.[9] These habits, gestures, and skills might be called embodied memories. Here memory is imitative. Habits, gestures, and skills must be learned, and by repeating them tradition is transmitted. So in this domain memory might also be called natural memory. This memory is unmediated, direct, and something that is not being reflected upon. If a farmer uses a tool, he may have learned to use that tool from his ancestors, but that is not something he reflects upon while using that tool. A Catholic visiting his church on Sunday will worship his God; he will not reflect on his God being worshipped in a certain way.

In the realm of tradition, there is no difference to be made between tradition on the one hand and being conscious of that tradition on the other, for they are one. Habits, gestures, and skills used, are consciously performed actions embodying tradition, but they are not the object of conscious reflection. In being part of tradition, the object accumulates its history unnoticed. The moment one becomes conscious of tradition is the moment tradition is on the verge of getting lost, only to be remembered or represented. This brings us to the second domain.

The environment of preservation is the domain of what remains from the past, the domain of materiality. Here the environment becomes a site of memory, a *lieux de mémoire*, as Pierre Nora has called it.[10] This is the moment in which the farmer's plow is no longer used for plowing, the moment God is no longer worshipped, the cave painting stops assisting hunts, and the statue loses its imperial power, even though they all will still be there to be visited. Of essential importance is that memory here refers to what has been lost. The objects we encounter on a site of memory, once part of tradition, now *remind* us of that tradition.[11] What once was, then, becomes part of our former selves. This is according to Nora our present condition: "It is no longer genesis that we seek but instead the decipherment of what we are in the light of what we are no longer".[12] Frank Ankersmit would say that the object expresses a thought or a feeling, something that we *sense*, making us conscious of what we are no longer.[13] A plow may remind

[9] This characterization is Pierre Nora's (1989, p. 13).

[10] According to Nora (1989, p.12): "*Lieux de mémoire* originate with the sense that there is no spontaneous memory, that we must deliberately create archives, maintain anniversaries, organize celebrations, pronounce eulogies, and notarize bills because such activities no longer occur naturally."

[11] Monuments and memorials are sites of memory too, reminding us of what once was and is no longer. A ritual of commemoration, on the other hand, is, as ritual, part of tradition. Most monuments and memorials have lost their ability to remind us of what is no longer and have become what below will be called documents of the past.

[12] Nora (1989, p.18).

[13] This awareness of what we are no longer is what Ankersmit calls historical experience. Here I have his analyses of Guardi's painting *Arcade with a Lantern* and his analyses of Hegel on the conflict between Socrates and the Athenian state in mind. See Ankersmit (Stanford 2005, respectively pp. 266-280 and pp.

us of a lost agricultural tradition, a church of a lost tradition of devotion, a cave painting of a lost world of magic, and an imperial statue may remind us of a lost world of divine earthly rule. On a site of memory, tradition is not handed over, but one becomes aware of the break with tradition, of a past being over.[14] No longer is the object connected to its original environment and use value. Instead, the connection between the object and its origin and history has become a *reflective* one.[15]

Here our heritage may have a *critical* function and stimulate us to reflect on our present day by questioning it. It does so if it reminds us of what we are no longer. We not only need to be critical towards the past, the past must be equally critical towards the present as well. The first is the concern of history as a science, the latter of history in its public function.

In the domain of preservation the object becomes a means for reflection on what has been and thus triggers what is known as historical consciousness. The object's accumulated history, unnoticed in the realm of tradition, has now surfaced. Tradition and being conscious of tradition have separated, the former having become the object of the latter. Tradition, memory, and history, are closely related notions.[16] The moment traditions are historicized is the moment historiography can come into being.

Not only material objects and its related practices may remind us of what we are no longer. An important addition to this must be made. Historical narratives may show us what tradition was like. As such they would be part of the domain of representation. But historical

330-334).

[14] Since its inception it was complained that museums destroy "the life of art and history by preserving it" as Didier Maleuvre (1999, pp. 1-2) puts it. Maleuvre furthermore writes (1999, p.5): "For Balzac the museum symbolizes a break in the traditional transmission from the past: in the museum, the past is not handed over to a new generation; rather, it is exhibited as an alienated and decontextualized object, at once estranged and strange". But see below n15.

[15] This is a Hegelian theme. According to Maleuvre (1999, p.27) "to Hegel, the mediation of historical consciousness has the opposite effect of the alienation commonly imputed to it: plucking the artwork out of its natural context does not sever it from its context but presents this context as what it in fact always is, a product of mind. Hegel would say that the relation of the Elgin marbles to antiquity (...) is more reflective once this connection is actually taken out of its immediate circumstance (...). The relation of the statue to its cultural origin stands out more clearly as a *reflective* connection, *rather* than a natural one". Maleuvre (1999, p.28) then goes on explaining that it follows that, if historians for example look at antiquity, they may better grasp what antiquity was like than the people who lived in antiquity.

[16] After discussion several explanations for the rise of memory in historical discourse from the end of the nineteen eighties onwards, Kerwin Klee Klein (2000, p.145) concludes that we want memory to "re-enchant our relation with the world and pour presence back into the past". This can be interpreted as a desire to relate ourselves to tradition, by either being part of it or by remembering of once being part of it. Our relationship with tradition by means of its historiographic representation is according to Klein (and others) in crises: "It is no accident that our sudden fascination with memory goes hand in hand with postmodern reckonings of history as the marching black boot and of historical consciousness as an oppressive fiction. Memory can come to the fore in an age of historiographic crisis precisely because it figures as a therapeutic alternative to historical discourse. Here Klein comes close to Nora (1989, pp. 10-11), although not being aware of that. Nora also points at the crises in historiography, that is, "the reflexive turning of history upon itself" and its failure to relate to tradition. On the diverse relationships history and memory are presumed to have, see Geoffrey Cubitt (2007, pp. 26-65).

narratives may also express a sense of what we are no longer. Inasmuch as we are able to *identify* ourselves with what is being expressed, the work may transform the immediate environment of the reader into a site a memory, thus in a way functioning as a site of memory by itself. What is no longer then becomes a memory of our former selves, transcending the boundaries of our personal history into the remote past.

The third domain is the domain of representation, of photographs, of description, of metadata, and of information on the provenance of objects. This is the domain of documentation. Instead of memory being imitative, as in the domain of tradition, memory is mimetic. Memory itself is being preserved by being stored, but it no longer needs to be remembered for it is already represented. Being conscious of tradition now is mediated by representation. Consciousness and tradition, although seemingly opposed since the representation stands for the represented, are actually one, for the representation defines what the represented tradition was like. This is why the domain of representation is also the domain of invented traditions, of representations that suggest to represent traditions that in fact never existed.[17] To be sure, not all represented traditions are invented traditions.

In this domain, heritage has no critical function, although the representation itself can be the result of an critical attitude towards the heritage it represents. For tradition or cultural heritage to have a critical function, it must remind us of what we are no longer. And that cannot be achieved by representing heritage *as if* we were part of it. That only shows us what it would have been like. An object reminding us of what we are no longer does not function on the level of representation, but on the level of memory. As an image a photograph shows as what the past was like, whereas its materiality may remind us of what we are no longer.[18]

The domain of representation is also the domain of reproduction and reconstruction. Some museums are sites of documentation rather than sites of memory. This is the case when their collection consists of reproductions instead of original objects, for reproductions have never been part of the domain of tradition. A reproduction is a representation of a thing belonging to tradition.[19] Museums are also sites of documentation when they reconstruct or simulate the domain of tradition. Then the exhibition of objects purports to show the past as

[17] On invented traditions, see Eric Hobsbawm and Terence Ranger eds. (1983).
[18] Materiality and being an image might not be that easy separated. But there is a difference in triggering a memory of what has been and representing what it has been like. Since objects easily turn into representations (see below), the function of representation will presumable in most cases take the upper hand. On the distinction between the photograph's materiality and the photograph being an image and the ambivalence the distinction gives rise to, see Michael Roth (2009).
[19] A plow is a mass produced object and in that sense a reproduction. But a plow is not a representation of a plow once belonging to tradition. A plow can be representative of tradition and represent it.

then contemporaries saw it, thus aiming at (an illusion of) immediacy.[20] A reconstruction of a peasant village documents that village, just as the reconstructed cave of Lascaux documents the original cave and its paintings, turning the reconstruction into a document itself. So called experience rooms, historic theme parks, re-enactments, and historical films, all fall under this rubric of reconstructions of tradition.

Preserving objects easily turns into documenting them. This so happens when the object becomes valued for its representative qualities instead of its particularity. If an artwork is considered to be representative of some period style, then the artwork will document or represent that period style. So an artwork may express a lost tradition of worship, but once the painting is representative of late medieval art, the painting loses its expressive power. It follows that museums should be careful when exhibiting their artworks in an art historical context, that is, as long as they want their artworks to work and embody their historicity. When we start seeing museums as centers of information rather than as repositories of particular objects,[21] we deprive museums of their role as sites of memory and allocate them the function of documentation-centers only.

**4. Tradition revisited**

Many cultural heritage institutions are by now familiar with reproducing their collections using information technology. The digital reproduction process of cultural heritage consists mostly of digital imaging. Far from purporting to be surrogates of original objects, these digital images represent relevant features of the objects they reproduce.[22] Of course, even if they were surrogates – holograms hovering above our terminals – they would still be reproductions and therefore representations of original objects. Many cultural heritage institutions also provide online search-engines to search their database. These databases are documentations (representations) of collections. Museums may also try to get users involved in this documentation process by tempting them to tag objects. Also virtual reconstructions, simulations, 3D modeling and Geographic Information Systems (GIS) are representations of the objects and their original environment, whether online accessible or as part of a museum exhibition. Digital media enabling access to cultural heritage belong to the domain of

[20] Allan Megill (2007, p. 214) warns us about this sort of aesthesis (sensation) of history in our present day culture. In line with what we have said, Megill argues that it withholds us from experiencing a break between "what we *are* now and what *other were* then".
[21] In 1992, the then director of the Canadian Museum of Civilization George MacDonald argued for seeing museums as information centers. See Cameron (2007, pp.51-52).
[22] David Arnold (2008, p.159).

representation only. The virtual museum may for that reason be called a documentation-museum.

By arguing that the virtual museum is a documentation-museum representing our cultural heritage, we do not return to using binary oppositions to formulate the difference that digital media makes. For a digital object in a virtual museum and a material object encountered in an environment of documentation are no different in that they both represent our cultural heritage, even if the former is immaterial and virtual and the latter material and real.[23]

If an object is representative, the distinction between that object and its documentation evaporates, for the object is itself a document. In a digital environment, in which collections are documentations, the distinction between an object and its documentation can also no longer be maintained. Of course, there is still a distinction to be made between the digital image of some object and its written documentation. But the distinction between the digital image itself and the written documentation is no longer a distinction between an object and its documentation. Not so much because the boundaries between texts and images are blurring in digital environments (images are no longer primarily illustrative of accompanying texts and texts are no longer primarily comments on accompanying images), but simple because both the digital image and the written accounts are data files documenting cultural heritage.

Digital imaging, simulations, search engines, 3D modeling and so forth, are the outcome of a process in which documentation is taking the place of sites of memories, just as from the 19th century onwards sites of memory started taking the place of natural memory. Nora prophesized along these lines that: "A generalized critical history would no doubt preserve some museums, some medallions and monuments (...) but it would empty them of what, to us, would make them *lieux de mémoire*. In the end, a society living wholly under the sign of history could not, any more than could a traditional society, conceive such sites for anchoring its memory."[24] History, virtual or not, in the sense of a representation or documentation of tradition (and thus *not* expressing what one is no longer) causes sites of memory to disappear. In the age of documentation, we relate ourselves to tradition by means of its representation. Cultural heritage, then, *is* its documentation. Remembering tradition is exchanged for representing it. This shift does not limit itself to virtual environments only but applies to physical museums as well. If curators no longer experience the objects before compiling an exhibition and only consult their database, that is, their documentation, it is clear that a shift from sites of memories to sites of

[23] Cameron argues against the non-materiality of digital objects and concludes (2007, p.70): "Both modalities, the analog and the digital, are material objects by definition, each acting as testimony to its own history and origin, and hence authenticity and aura". This we can agree with inasmuch objects are representative of some part of the past and authenticity is taken in its second sense of documentation.
[24] Nora (1989, p.9).

documentation has taken place inside the museum itself. Evidently is the use of digital media inside museums exemplary of this shift too.

Above we distinguished between two senses of authenticity. The virtual museum is foremost a documentation-museum, representing unique objects by documenting them. As a consequence, authenticity in the sense of documentation is becoming dominant in our time, taking the place of authenticity in the sense of the object's collected history.

That in the age of documentation we no longer relate ourselves to tradition otherwise than by means of its representation, would however not be the entire story. Two recent developments must be mentioned here. First, museums also use the web to collect information such as stories about the local environment of its users. These stories not only document the local environment, but may also transform that local environment into a site of memory. If you come to know that your favorite park was a palatine in the past, you may experience visiting that park differently. This may explain the popularity of local environment projects. A second development to be mentioned here is the technology known as augmented reality. Think for example of the possibility of walking down the street and watching on your iPhone pictures of that street from a century ago. The pictures themselves document the environment, but while walking down the street they may also transform the environment into a site of memory,[25] reminding us of what we are no longer, thereby questioning our present day so we do not take it for granted. If so, authenticity in the sense of the object's collected history, its historicity, might still be part of our sense of cultural heritage.

Transforming environments into sites of memory is not limited to local environment projects and augmented reality applications. All representation can make us see the world we live in differently. The point is that when tradition is represented, there usually is no need to remind ourselves of it.

So there is this possibility that as some point we only relate ourselves to tradition by representing it. That would be the moment in which places of memory are exchanged for the presence of representations. I am not sure if or when that moment arrives. Time will not tell, for only places can.

[25] In the description of augmented reality by Nadia Magnenat-Thalmann and George Papagiannakis (2006, pp. 419-430), the augmented reality application turns into a simulation and thus *not* transforms the environment into a site of memory.

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